

Sukkot as a Home with the Holy One

Dwelling with Him in the Sukkah — On Halakhic Burden as Religious Experience

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The distinctive colors of the festival of Sukkot stand out especially against the background of the Days of Awe that precede it. The month of Elul, Rosh Hashanah, the Ten Days of Repentance and Yom Kippur cast over that stretch of time an atmosphere of seriousness, of awe, of holiness. These are times in which a person deals, with gravity, with the foundations of his life — who is the king of his world; who determines and decrees his fate; along which paths he himself has chosen, and will choose, to walk in his life; whether he is capable of purification, of a new beginning; whether he is worthy of atonement. Out of this weighty melody, an entirely different note suddenly bursts forth — a festival whose voice is the voice of thanksgiving and song, the voice of the joy of life. After a period of the fear of God, comes the turn of the divine love — "his left hand is under my head, and his right hand embraces me." The left hand, which expresses judgment, the Days of Awe, leads to the loving-kindness of the right hand, to the joy of the love of God.

The love between man and his God is the theme of the festival. The laws of the festival express this through the shaping of the sukkah in the image of the chuppah, the wedding canopy under which a couple celebrate their marriage. Under the chuppah, the couple live together for the first time, as a couple, for at least seven days; this is their first shared home. As their shared life continues, the couple will move to permanent homes, to larger and more spacious apartments, to a full and busy family life — and yet every home in which they will live will try to preserve something of the unique experience of the chuppah, something of the freshness and primal romance of the bond, something of the excitement and love of "entering the chuppah," of the moment of forging the marriage covenant.

That very same thing happens in the sukkah, between us and the Holy One. In the sukkah we experience a real touch, the presence of the Shekhinah. The Holy One^[1] invites us to set aside for Him a special temporary dwelling; we respond to Him and come to sit in His shade, and He, for His part, wraps us in a faithful embrace. All this in order to remind us of the beginning of our shared path, of the walk through the wilderness that followed the redemption from Egypt, and in order to instill that special love, so strong in its presence, also throughout the rest of the ordinary days, throughout the whole year. To bring the temporariness and the primalness of the love into the permanence, into the routine and ordinary days of life.

One of the central strata in which the divine presence appears in our daily lives is the halakhic demand. We are required to obey the instructions of halakha across an unlimited

range of areas of our lives, whether these are matters of great importance or matters of no consequence, whether these are fateful decisions or truly trivial ones. For the most part, we accept the great things halakha places before us with greater ease: to keep a kosher kitchen, to sanctify the seventh day of the week from labor and work, to observe certain standards of modesty in social life, and so on. By contrast, quite often the harder sense of collision and of nuisance is found specifically in the encounter with halakhic pettiness. The great values we understand, broadly; the basic directional calls we internalize; with the overarching visions we identify. But it is hard, simply hard, to understand how so small a detail, so unimportant, so puzzling, can be the embodiment of the will of God.

It is not always the very descent into small details that is troubling. It seems to me that there are often times when even the content of the halakhic provisions themselves is difficult; but I do not mean the truly principled clashes, in which the Torah and Judaism clearly set out a value-conception opposed to the one we hold, but rather the places where the particular halakhic demand seems to express no grand and sublime principle whatsoever. Here the sense of oppressiveness is, in many ways, stronger — instead of a confrontation of debate, a more abyssal inability to understand arises, as between two people who do not speak the same language at all. Halakha demands of us to do a certain thing in the name of the will of God, but we fail to understand what the connection is between the will of God and this thing, how halakha arrived at this conclusion. Halakha has an inner language, a kind of unique logic, an independent rhythm; but all these are, at times, far from the other tools by which we seek the will of God, such as common sense, natural morality, or philosophical thought. Halakha remains faithful to itself and to its own inner dynamic alone — one that, in our eyes, can at times be strange, puzzling and incomprehensible. And then the conclusions it reaches obligate us! And in the name of the will of God, no less!

It seems to me, then, that halakha arouses in us not only difficulty — in the sense of obligations hard to perform, which demand overcoming drives or habits or deep wills — but, beyond this, a subtle but oppressive feeling of botheration. It is not that it is a great toil for me to tie my shoes in this specific order, but that this pettiness bothers me, something about it is ridiculous and infuriating, something about identifying it with the Holy One is absurd, unacceptable.

It turns out that our central obstacle to accepting this exactingness is theological — it is hard for us to picture the divine demand as descending to small and inessential details. This theological conception sketches a God whose main "role" is in the realm of ideas, of supreme morality, of behavioral foundations and their principles, of life's basic experiences and their content — in short, only in great manifestations of spirit. When we encounter a petty demand in the name of the word of God, and are asked to attribute to God an "interest" in tiny tasks devoid of any general moral significance — we recoil, and in some sense see in this a dimension of anthropomorphizing God. Our religious aspirations are supposed to find expression in other places, so much higher, so much more sublime. Whereas our religion comes and chokes us with legal minutiae, placing the encounter with God in the side drawers of life, in some pointless and glory-less demand.

We are called to a different theological horizon. It is not for nothing that the Torah repeated, the Prophets doubled, and the Sages tripled the comparison of the bond between man and God to the bond of husband and wife — "and you shall love the LORD your God." And indeed, love is a sublime feeling, a feeling one feels amid an elevation of spirit, a feeling that undoubtedly stands at the pinnacle, at the top floor of the edifice of human feelings. But love is not only all this; it is not only the endearing sweeping-away of the forging of the bond, it is not only the fulfilling momentum of the making of the covenant, it is not only the ecstatic excitement of entering the chuppah. Love is realized in life, and it is realized in life in a very specific way: to live together in that same house.

When a couple marry, they decide to forge a covenant that binds them together always, in a bond that is obligating, mutual and demanding. True, one marries when one loves, and romantic ardor is the sap that animates the marriage and grants it its happiness and the foundation of pleasure within it. But from the moment the marriage covenant is forged, the couple no longer choose; they are obligated to one another, and are called upon to live with one another — even when it is burdensome, even when it is unromantic, even when they are tired or irritable, and even when the other has his or her "quirks." A person who enters a covenant is a person who has brought into his world a binding element of supreme validity, which overrides his momentary will. In this self-transcendence, in this departure from the banality that exists in a life confined to egocentric or materialistic wants, a person acquires meaning and content for his life and rescues himself from emptiness. This overcoming of my natural will in order to make room for the wills of my spouse finds its most powerful expression precisely in the most esoteric and marginal of places, precisely in the pettiest and most irritating of frictions, precisely in occasions devoid of the slightest trace of heroism, greatness or romance.

The experience of marriage with the Holy One does not pass only through experiences of depth or through ecstatic emotional outbursts; it is a way of life in which we must live with the Holy One. Every minor halakha is a profound test within this relationship of ours with the Holy One, and we are called upon to meet it even when we are not stirred and in love, and even when we are irritated by the whole matter. This is the only way to keep a covenant.

If we decide that only the full, heroic, sublime and soul-elevating experience is an experience bound up with divine presence, we sentence ourselves to a life that is in practice more distant from God. The soul cannot remain in the tension and sublimity of the fully glorious religious experience; its nature is to live also feelings that are more mundane, lower, of a fainter vitality and color. This resembles the experience of the "spark" of romantic falling-in-love — the kind that insists that all matters of the couple's bond be carried out only from the supreme feeling of love as burning coals, and does not allow itself an ordinary, this-worldly coupledness, a coupledness realized over the course of an entire life. Therefore, we must determine that our religiosity is founded upon an experience of dialogue and of standing as a couple before God from whatever state or place we find ourselves in — even out of laziness or gloom, even out of apathy and lack of identification,

even out of bitterness and even out of irritation and anger. From wherever we are, we shall stand before God and carry out His requests, in the submission of love. Only in this way does one attain a conscious presence of the love of God in life.

On the festival of Sukkot we emphasize and renew precisely this facet of our relationship with the Holy One. The sukkah is our wedding canopy with the Holy One; it is our shared home. The basic experience is that a person enters the sukkah, and God hovers over him in His Shekhinah. But the sukkah expresses not only an experience of sublime, exhilarating union, but also the constant and difficult demand to live together with God in a home, exactly as a married couple. Immediately after the celebration of "entering the chuppah," the chuppah becomes the shared dwelling of the couple for seven full days, which are not saturated with that same emotional intensity as the wedding itself. Suddenly the couple experiences that which will accompany them throughout their married life — shared dwelling. A total "togetherness," with all the small and large challenges and difficulties bound up with it. In exactly the same way, the commandment of the festival is to dwell in the sukkah for seven days, and to make the sukkah our home in every sense, to the point that we are called upon to perform even the most basic and banal actions of our existence in the sukkah.

The sense of bother present in keeping the laws of the festival — hauling the lulav along on a two-day trip, searching for a sukkah in order to eat waffles, trying not to fall into a fitful sleep during some lecture — is itself the unique religious experience of the festival, of forging a covenant and building a home with God. True, this is a celebration — the seven days of the marriage feast, a remembrance and refreshing of the joy of the beginning of shared life — but it is also, in effect, an ideal, yet at the same time real and possible, model of shared life as a whole. Our very lives are a home that we build together with God, and He dwells within them and sets within them both His demands, on the one hand, and His goodness and lovingkindness, on the other. We need not fulfill the halakhic demands only from a place of identification, connection and understanding every time. True, this is a pleasant, beautiful and ideal place from which to fulfill the will of the Holy One, but the covenant finds its expression precisely where identification is absent, where lack of understanding turns into lack of agreement and patience runs out. In these situations we are given the opportunity to fulfill halakha out of simple, loving devotion, out of a deep conjugal concession, out of a unique consciousness of home-ness and dialogue with God. The life of the covenant, life with the Holy One as a married couple sharing a roof — as within the sukkah — is the only way of life in which we are truly bound together in deep love with God, and in which we have the option to delight in Him with the supreme pleasure of devotion, "I delighted to sit in His shade, and His fruit was sweet to my taste."

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1. "And behold, it is now known, that which our Sages of blessed memory said, that the essential [walls] of the sukkah are two walls according to their halakhic requirement, and a third even a

handbreadth, and this refers to the matter of the embrace of the arm mentioned above — that when a person embraces his wife, she stands face to face with him, and is then embraced by his arm. Now, in the arm there are three joints... and this is [the meaning of] two [walls] according to their halakhic requirement, and a third even a handbreadth." (Peri Etz Chaim, Sha'ar Chag Ha-Sukkot, ch. 4)